

A 1909 house in Bernal Heights

Bernal Heights, San Francisco · 3 bed / 1 full + 1 half bath · built 1909 · RH-1

Package reviewed: 241 pages, 14 documents, compiled 20 July 2026.

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CONDITION SCORE / 100

This is a normal 1909 Bernal Heights house with two things that are not normal. The pest report is a Section 1 report — active fungus damage and beetle infestation — and it reaches the foundation sills, a beam, and the support post bases. Separately, the seller does not know whether the downstairs bedroom and laundry were ever permitted, and the City's own record says they were not.

Those two findings share a cause. The lower level was finished at some point, and that finish now conceals the substructure in exactly the areas where damage was confirmed at the accessible edges. **The known repair figure is a floor, not a ceiling**, and this review is built around narrowing it before you remove contingencies.

\$29–76k

TO MAKE IT SOUND

6

SECTION 1 PEST FINDINGS

3

PERMITS EVER ISSUED

2

INSPECTIONS STILL TO BUY

The three things that matter.

1. The City has no record of the downstairs bedroom or laundry.

The seller checked **Yes** to alterations or repairs made without necessary permits and wrote: *not sure about history of permits re: downstairs bedroom/laundry room.*

The City's record settles it. The Report of Residential Building Record lists **three permits in the building's entire history** — termite control in 1978, a kitchen remodel in 2003, and replacing some boards on the side of the house in 2012. There is no permit for finishing a lower level, adding a bedroom, adding a bathroom or adding a laundry. Authorised occupancy is a **one-family dwelling** in an RH-1 district.

Both inspectors independently flagged the same thing without being told: the home inspector noted *sections of this building may have been remodeled* and, in the lower floor section, *non-original construction was noted* — we suggest review of all plans and permits.

Why it matters to you, in three ways. The house is marketed as three bedrooms; if the third is unpermitted, an appraiser may not count it and a lender may not either. Unpermitted living space can be required to be legalised or removed if the City is ever prompted. And a downstairs bedroom with its own bathroom in an RH-1 district raises a question you want answered in writing before you are committed — that it is legal habitable space and not an unwarranted second unit.

TDS Section C.4 and explanation (7/18/2026); SF DBI Report of Residential Building Record, issued 15 Jun 2026; home inspection items 6 and 232.

2. The pest report is Section 1, and it is structural.

Six Section 1 findings — meaning active infestation or infection, not merely conditions that could lead to it:

- **Fungus damage to a beam** in the substructure.
- **Foundation sills and framing bases damaged**, with the caution that if damage extends beyond the outlined area a supplemental report and cost estimate will follow.
- **Fungus damage and beetle infestation at the front porch and stair assembly**, with faulty grade and earth contact at the bases of walls and stairs. Remedy is to reframe and install raised concrete footings.
- **Support post bases lack proper footing and are fungus damaged** — cut off, remove damage, install raised concrete pier footings.
- Corner trim and window trim fungus damaged.

Every Bay Area house of this age carries some dry rot, and trim is close to meaningless. These are not that. **Sills, a beam, and post bases are load path**, and the home inspector found the same items independently: the mudsill damaged at the front right, the beam at right rear deteriorated, and the moisture membrane at the front stairs failed with water damage to the support structure below.

No cost estimate was issued. The report prices nothing. That is unusual on a Section 1 report and it is your first ask.

WDO Inspection Report, 19 May 2026, Section 1 items 1–6; home inspection items 31, 32, 54, 57.

3. Nobody has actually seen the substructure.

The pest inspector's closing note: *garage/basement framing is finished and sealed. Framing is inaccessible to inspection. Further inspection will entail removal of finished materials.* The home inspector says the same — *due to the installation of finished surfaces and personal/storage items, the majority of the basement and foundation is inaccessible* — and adds that wall framing and subflooring are concealed and could not be visually inspected.

So the confirmed damage is what was visible at the edges of a sealed cavity. Set against the seller's disclosure of **water intrusion in the downstairs bedroom and laundry room in 2024 and 2025**, and at the kitchen French door in various years, the question is not whether more will be found but how much.

The offsetting facts are real and worth stating. The basement was **dry on the day of inspection** with no adverse moisture conditions observed. The mudsill is bolted, anchor bolts are present, and beam-to-post strapping has been installed. The house is **not** on the soft-story list and **not** unreinforced masonry. The inspector's overall structural verdict is that all structural elements appear to be performing as expected for a building of this age and type.

WDO information item; home inspection items 51, 55, 56, 62, 65; SF Seller Disclosure D.13, D.14, D.17; TDS Section C explanation.

What is genuinely strong.

- **The seismic work is done.** Mudsill bolted to foundation, anchor bolts observed, beam-to-post strapping installed, basement perimeter walls reinforced with plywood shearwall. On a 1909 Bernal house that is the expensive item, and it is behind you.
- **Not soft-story, not unreinforced masonry**, and not in the Mandatory Earthquake Retrofit Program. No City retrofit obligation attaches to this purchase.
- **Title is clean.** No easements, no CC&Rs, no HOA, no liens beyond the seller's own mortgage, and no conveyances in the last 24 months. Both instalments of the 2025–26 tax bill are paid.
- **Owner-occupied since January 2019.** No tenants, no Ellis Act history, no owner move-in eviction, no buyout agreements — the whole San Francisco tenancy dimension is absent.
- **Not in a flood risk zone** under the SFPUC 100-Year Storm map, and the Certificate of Energy and Water Compliance was recorded 4 June 2026.
- **Electrical basics are sound.** Service capacity adequate for present demand, subpanel correctly installed and fused, and GFCI protection present everywhere currently required.

What it costs to make sound.

ITEM	SOURCE	PLANNING ESTIMATE
STRUCTURAL AND PEST — SECTION 1, DO NOT DEFER		
Foundation sills and framing bases — remove and replace damaged members, chemical treatment	WDO item 2; home insp. #54	\$4,000 — \$12,000
Front porch and stair assembly — reframe, raised concrete footings, treat for beetle infestation	WDO item 3; home insp. #32	\$6,000 — \$15,000
Substructure beam — remove fungus damage, reconstruct	WDO item 1; home insp. #57	\$2,500 — \$6,000
Support post bases — cut off, install raised concrete pier footings	WDO item 4	\$2,500 — \$6,000
Rear deck — damaged joists and post lower pads	Home insp. #31	\$3,000 — \$8,000
Break earth-to-wood contact at rear and at stair bases	WDO item 3; home insp. #21	\$800 — \$2,000
WATER PATH — THE DISCLOSED LEAKS		
Rear French doors and frames — weather damaged and delaminating; the kitchen-to-deck leak point	WDO note; TDS Section C	\$3,500 — \$9,000
Exterior doors and jambs damaged in areas	Home insp. #23	\$1,500 — \$4,000
Corner trim, window trim, fascia, deteriorated trim, prep and repaint	WDO items 5–6; home insp. #39, #40, #44	\$4,000 — \$10,000
SAFETY — SMALL, QUICK, NON-NEGOTIABLE		
Ungrounded three-prong receptacles in several areas — ground properly or restore to two-prong	Home insp. #97, #179, #203, #226	\$600 — \$2,000
Voids in the fire-resistive barrier between garage and interior	Home insp. #135	\$400 — \$1,200
Seismic automatic gas shutoff valve; meter wrench	Home insp. #117, #118	\$500 — \$900
Total, on what is currently visible		\$29,300 — \$76,100

Planning assumptions for budgeting, not bids, and not sourced from any quotation. The spread is wide because it is genuinely uncertain: the sealed substructure means the quantity of damaged sill and framing is unknown, and the pest report expressly warns that a supplemental report and cost estimate will issue if damage extends beyond the outlined area.

What is not in that number.

Knob and tube. The house runs a mix of knob and tube and modern romex, and the K&T circuits are ungrounded. This is the normal condition for an unremodelled 1909 San Francisco house and the inspector's recommendation is appropriately soft — replace *as upgrades and maintenance projects are undertaken*, not urgently. Budget **\$8,000–\$25,000** whenever you open walls. The one thing to check now is your insurer's appetite, because carriers differ sharply.

The roof. Composition shingle and smooth rolled over a combination of steep and low pitch, with surface granulation deteriorating and minor cracks developing. No roof report was obtained and the inspector recommends a licensed roofer evaluate remaining life. Until someone does, treat **\$15,000–\$30,000** as an unscheduled reserve rather than a known cost.

Confirm before you remove contingencies.

- 1. Buy two inspections the seller did not. A sewer lateral camera survey** — the home inspector explicitly recommends a full camera review of the entire waste system, no test was done, and on a 1909 Bernal house with clay laterals this is the single highest-value \$400 you will spend. And a **destructive-access pest inspection of the sealed garage and basement framing**, which the pest company will perform on request. Ask the seller for access and for the cost to be credited.
- 2. Get the Section 1 work bid.** The pest report contains findings and no prices. Ask for the issuing company's written estimate on all six Section 1 items plus the further-inspection item. A number from the seller's own inspector is worth far more in negotiation than a number from yours.
- 3. Resolve the downstairs in writing.** Ask the seller and the listing agent directly whether the lower-level bedroom, bathroom and laundry were permitted; if the answer remains "not sure", have your agent pull the permit history and confirm with DBI and Planning what would be required to legalise the space — and confirm it is not treated as a second unit. Also note the **2003 kitchen remodel permit is recorded as EXPIRED**, meaning it was issued and never finalized.
- 4. Check the square footage you are paying for.** The MLS and public record show 1,196 sf. The price per foot reported for the 2019 sale implies roughly 925 sf. Those cannot both be right. If the difference is the unpermitted lower level, then the figure in the listing and the figure an appraiser uses may not match.

Also worth knowing.

- **Built 1909 — lead paint is presumed.** The federal disclosure is in the package. Relevant if you plan to sand, strip or renovate, and relevant with young children.
- **Conditions conducive to fungi were noted generally**, and the inspector recommends evaluation by a fungal specialist. Standard language, but it pairs with the disclosed downstairs water intrusion.
- **No roof report, no sewer report, no soils report** were provided. The seller supplied a general inspection, pest, energy and water compliance, and the 3R.
- **Stair and deck railings are outdated by present standards;** the inspector recommends modification to eliminate hazards, particularly for children. There are also no graspable handrails on parts of the exterior stairs.
- **Ivy at the rear left** should be removed — it is a moisture and pest vector on a house already showing fungus damage.
- **Property tax will rise on sale.** The 2025–26 tax bill runs at an effective rate near 1.23% of the assessed value. Every \$100,000 of purchase price above that adds roughly \$1,230 a year.

The bottom line.

Nothing here should stop you buying this house. Bernal Heights is trading fiercely — every comparable sale in the last six months closed above its asking price — and a 1909 house with the seismic work already done, clean title, no tenancy history and a dry basement is a reasonable thing to want.

But two of the three findings are unpriced and one of them is unmeasured, and that is a poor position from which to waive a contingency. **Buy the sewer camera and the destructive-access pest inspection, get the Section 1 work bid by the company that wrote the report, and get the permit question answered in writing.** All four can be done inside a normal investigation period and together they cost under a thousand dollars.

Then negotiate on a number rather than a range. On what is visible today the work runs \$29,300 to \$76,100, and the reason for that spread is a sealed cavity that somebody should open before you own it rather than after.

Sources. Real Estate Transfer Disclosure Statement and Text Overflow Addendum No. 1 (7/18–7/20/2026); San Francisco Seller Disclosure, 8 pages (7/2026); Residential Earthquake Risk Disclosure; California Lead-Based Paint Disclosure; general home inspection report, 35 pages, inspection dated 19 May 2026; Wood Destroying Pests and Organisms Inspection Report, 19 May 2026; San Francisco Department of Building Inspection Report of Residential Building Record (3R), issued 15 June 2026; Energy and Water Conservation Inspection and Compliance certificates, recorded 4 June 2026; Fidelity National Title preliminary report (printed 7/07/2026); CoreLogic property detail report (7/20/2026); statutory and local advisories and Natural Hazard Disclosure report as compiled 20 July 2026.

This review summarises documents supplied in the seller's disclosure package and is not an inspection, an appraisal, or legal advice. Cost figures are planning estimates for budgeting only and are not bids; no quotation has been obtained for any item. Permit and zoning conclusions are drawn from the City's own 3R report and should be confirmed directly with the Department of Building Inspection and the Planning Department. Nothing here substitutes for your own inspections and professional advice within your contractual investigation period. Prepared by Tim McMullen, Licensed Real Estate Agent, CA DRE #02016832 · McMullen Properties LLC, under Real Broker · 415-691-9272.